MODULE 13 · DOMAIN 3 - PRODUCT AND MODEL SELECTION

Context, Memory and When to Start Again

The context window as working memory, feeding long material well, long chats, the handover, and what Claude remembers between chats.

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Claude can only use what is in front of it, and it uses it best when the right things are there.

The context window: a meeting-room whiteboard

- **The context window is Claude's working memory** for one conversation, measured in tokens (pieces of words).
- **What fills it:** your messages and Claude's replies, pasted text and files, project instructions and knowledge, tool and connector results.
- **Bigger is not better:** irrelevant material competes for attention and uses your allowance faster.
- **Sizes vary by model and plan**, and Anthropic's own pages disagree. Check the current figure; do not memorise one.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> The exam tests what you put on the whiteboard, not how big the whiteboard is.

Feeding Claude long material

01
Trim
Only the sections the task needs.

02
Label
Wrap each document in tags with its source.

03
Material first
Long documents at the top.

04
Question last
Instructions and query at the end.

05
Quotes first
Ask for the relevant passages before the answer.

ON THE EXAM

Anthropic's guidance: long material at the top, the query at the end. Up to 30 percent better in its tests.

Quirk 1 revisited: the 300-page tender

BEFORE

Everything, question first

- Whole tender and appendices pasted in one go
- "What do they want?" at the top
- No sources, no sections named
- Answer misses a buried requirement

AFTER

Trimmed, labelled, question last

- Specification and mandatory sections only
- Each part tagged with its section number
- Question and output format at the end
- Quotes with section references first

THE TIEBREAKER

Module four split the job. This module shapes each piece of context.

Is the context the problem?

SYMPTOM	LIKELY CAUSE	FIX
Misses a detail buried in a long file	Too much material	Trim, label, question last
Ignores a rule set early on	Rule far back in a long chat	Restate the rule
Contradicts decisions from weeks ago	Outgrown its context	Summarise and start again
Generic, could fit any company	Context never given	Prompt fix: add the context
Slow, or near the limit	Large files, many tools	Drop extras and unused tools

ON THE EXAM

Missing context is a prompt problem. Too much or stale context is a context problem.

Long chats: keep them on track, or start again

- **Restate key constraints** when they matter again, rather than trusting a message from hours ago.
- **Summarise decisions as you go:** ask Claude for a short decision log at natural break points.
- **One job per chat.** A new topic deserves a new chat.
- **Start again when:** it contradicts agreed decisions, repeats errors you fixed, the topic has changed, or you keep re-explaining.

> THE TIEBREAKER
>
> Light drift: restate. Heavy drift or a new topic: summarise and start fresh.

Automatic context management

- **On paid plans with code execution on,** Claude summarises earlier messages as a chat nears the limit.
- **You may see it "organizing its thoughts".** The chat carries on instead of stopping.
- **The full history is kept** so Claude can refer back, and the summarising does not count against your usage.
- **A summary is not the original.** Detail from early in the chat can still blur.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> It keeps a long chat going. It does not keep every early detail sharp.

The handover: moving to a fresh start

01

Summarise

Ask Claude for decisions, constraints and open questions.

02

Decide what persists

Lasting material versus one-off detail.

03

Move it

Lasting material into a Project.

04

Start fresh

New chat, with the summary.

05

Check

Confirm it picked up the key decisions.

ON THE EXAM

Summarise before you leave. Check after you arrive.

Three kinds of remembering

	ANALOGY	SCOPE	GOOD FOR
Chat	A sticky note	This conversation only	One-off tasks
Project	The team's shared cabinet	Its own chats, knowledge, instructions and memory	Lasting material a team shares
Memory	A colleague's recollection	Your account, across your chats	Your role, preferences and ongoing work
Search past chats	Looking through old notes	Your earlier chats, within project boundaries	Finding what was said before

THE TIEBREAKER

Team knowledge goes in a Project. Personal preferences go in Memory.

Memory in 2026

- **Saved as individual topics** (July and August 2026). Read, edit or delete each one in Settings.
- **Say "remember this"** to add something; each Project keeps its own memory, apart from the rest.
- **Sensitive topics stay out** unless you choose to include them. Team and Enterprise: off by default.
- **Import from another AI tool** is experimental: review what arrives, and export before big changes.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Maintain Memory like a contact list: fix stale entries rather than starting over.

Pause, reset, or go off the record

PAUSE OR RESET

Your whole Memory

- Pause: memories kept, but not used or added to
- Reset: deletes all memories, project memories too
- Reset cannot be undone
- Export first if you might need them

INCOGNITO CHAT

One conversation

- Not saved to history or Memory
- Does not use existing Memory
- Never found by past-chat search
- Not available inside Projects

THE TIEBREAKER

One stale entry: edit it. A break from Memory: pause. A fresh start: export, then reset.

Context and memory traps

THE TRAP	WHY IT FAILS
Paste everything, just in case	The key line gets lost, and allowance is wasted
One chat for the whole project	Early decisions blur; contradictions creep in
Start fresh with no summary	Every decision has to be rebuilt from memory
Rely on personal Memory for team rules	Each person's Memory differs; a Project is shared
Reset Memory to fix one wrong fact	Deletes everything; editing one topic was enough
A bigger model to fix a cluttered context	Clutter confuses every model

ON THE EXAM

Every trap either overloads the whiteboard or wipes it without a handover.

> A Halden bid writer pastes a 300-page tender and three past bids into one message, with her question at the top: "List every mandatory requirement."
>
> Claude's list misses a mandatory requirement buried in an appendix.

What is the best fix?

A Switch to the most capable model and ask again

B Ask the same question again, more firmly

C Give only the requirements sections, labelled, with the question after them and quotes first

D Paste the tender into ten separate chats and combine the answers by hand

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What is the best fix?

A Switch to the most capable model and ask again

Clutter confuses every model; the context is the problem.

B Ask the same question again, more firmly

Same cluttered context, same result.

C Give only the requirements sections, labelled, with the question after them and quotes first

Trim, label, question last, quotes first.

D Paste the tender into ten separate chats and combine the answers by hand

Fragments the work and loses cross-references.

THE SIGNAL

Too much material, question first, missing detail: shape the context.

> Halden's communications manager has spent an afternoon drafting the supervisor newsletter in one chat. At the start she set three rules: under 300 words, British spelling, and no client names.
>
> The latest drafts run long and name a client. The work is nearly finished.

What is the best next step?

A Start a new chat with no context and begin again

B Restate the key constraints in her next message and ask Claude to check the draft against them

C Switch to a more capable model for the final draft

D Turn on Memory so Claude remembers the constraints

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What is the best next step?

A Start a new chat with no context and begin again

Throws away the work, and the rules, with no handover.

B Restate the key constraints in her next message and ask Claude to check the draft against them

Light drift on one topic, nearly done: restate and check.

C Switch to a more capable model for the final draft

The rules are far back, not too hard to follow.

D Turn on Memory so Claude remembers the constraints

Memory is for lasting preferences, not this chat's rules.

THE SIGNAL

One afternoon, one topic, nearly done: restate, do not restart.

> A Halden finance analyst wants Claude to compare the payment terms in three long supplier contracts against an internal audit report.
>
> She is preparing a single prompt with all four documents.

Which two practices will help Claude use the material well? Choose two.

- A Place the long documents at the top and the question at the end
- B Wrap each document in tags that name it and its source
- C Add every other contract the team holds, just in case
- D Put the question first, followed by all the documents
- E Turn on every available connector so Claude has more to draw on

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which two practices will help Claude use the material well? Choose two.

A Place the long documents at the top and the question at the end

Anthropic's own long-context guidance.

B Wrap each document in tags that name it and its source

Claude can tell the four documents apart and cite them.

C Add every other contract the team holds, just in case

Clutter that buries the four that matter.

D Put the question first, followed by all the documents

The reverse of the guidance.

E Turn on every available connector so Claude has more to draw on

Tools take context space and add noise.

THE SIGNAL

Order and labels help. More material and more tools only add clutter.

Quirk 9: Halden's operations team planned a depot move in one chat for three weeks. Claude now contradicts early decisions. The team decides to hand over to a fresh start.

(1) Start a new chat in the Project and give it the summary.

(2) Ask Claude to summarise the decisions, constraints and open questions.

(3) Ask a question that checks the new chat has the key decisions.

(4) Decide which material needs to persist for the rest of the move.

(5) Add the lasting material to the Project's knowledge.

What is the correct order?

A 2, 4, 5, 1, 3

B 4, 2, 5, 1, 3

C 2, 5, 4, 3, 1

D 1, 2, 4, 5, 3

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What is the correct order?

A 2, 4, 5, 1, 3

Summarise, decide, move, start fresh, check.

B 4, 2, 5, 1, 3

Decides what persists before anything is summarised.

C 2, 5, 4, 3, 1

Moves material before deciding what persists, and checks before starting.

D 1, 2, 4, 5, 3

Starts the new chat before there is a summary to give it.

THE SIGNAL

Anchor the ends: summarise first in the old chat, check last in the new one.

> Halden's IT owner has enabled Memory, and a bid manager turned it on months ago. She has since moved from the Birmingham hub to head office in Leeds.
>
> Claude keeps referring to her as Midlands-based. The rest of what it remembers is useful.

What should she do?

A Reset Memory, permanently deleting all of it

B Use incognito chats for all her future work

C Open her Memory settings and edit or delete the out-of-date topic

D Correct Claude in each chat whenever it happens

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should she do?

A Reset Memory, permanently deleting all of it

Deletes the useful memories to fix one stale fact.

B Use incognito chats for all her future work

Gives up Memory, and her chat history, entirely.

C Open her Memory settings and edit or delete the out-of-date topic

Fix the one stale entry; keep the rest.

D Correct Claude in each chat whenever it happens

Treats the symptom every time, never the cause.

THE SIGNAL

One stale fact, the rest useful: edit the topic.

> Halden's bid manager wants every bid writer's Claude to follow the house tender-response procedure and know the current list of client sectors.
>
> The procedure changes a few times a year, and twelve writers use it.

What is the best way to do this?

A Put the procedure and sector list in a shared Project's knowledge and instructions

B Ask each bid writer to tell Claude to remember the procedure

C Paste the procedure into every new chat

D Rely on search past chats to find the procedure when needed

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What is the best way to do this?

A Put the procedure and sector list in a shared Project's knowledge and instructions

One shared source, updated once, used by all twelve.

B Ask each bid writer to tell Claude to remember the procedure

Twelve personal Memories drift apart with every change.

C Paste the procedure into every new chat

Manual, inconsistent, and easy to paste an old version.

D Rely on search past chats to find the procedure when needed

Finds old conversations, not the current procedure.

THE SIGNAL

Shared, lasting, changes over time: a Project, not personal Memory.

In five lines

- **The context window is working memory.** The right things, not everything.
- **Long material:** trim, label, documents first, question last, quotes first.
- **Long chats:** light drift, restate; heavy drift, summarise and start again.
- **Handover:** summarise, decide what persists, move it, start fresh, check.
- **Team knowledge in a Project; personal preferences in Memory.** Edit stale topics; export before reset.

COMING UP

Next: Domain 4, use cases and requirements with Claude.